

With a study of Christian and Pre-communist Groups

And man creates the Gods or Weltanschauung; and
abides in this fata morgana, maintaining that
this is the ultimate reality.

- Yat

'Approaches to the science of Ultimate Concern'

Unique to man's history, and unique to man's history alone, is the emergence and development of religions or systems of ideology. They represent a quantum jump in the evolution of the species *Homo sapiens*, in which self-awareness is amalgamated with imagination. Religions and ideologies, defined ontologically, are organized structures of the manifold of human experiences and the unification of all orders of human interactions with the world. The hypothetical matrix of ultimate concern is multi-dimensional, as there are a multiplicity of approaches, systems and perspective spaces to these phenomena. Under this aspect, an eclectic approach from existential phenomenology to Marxian analysis, will be fruitful, when employed with ⁱⁿ a quasi-scientific methodology.

'The myth of piety - the mass psychosis of religions and ideologies'

The evolution of religions and dogmatic ideologies can be viewed as a compressed human psychological development from dependence to autonomy. In essence, the practice of religions and systems of ideology is a psychopathological regression to the natal or pre-natal stage of being - the fetus is absolutely dependent upon his mother. In fact, her womb is but his miniature universe; he can derive nourishment unconditionally from her. The process of birth is the genesis of alienation and the infant experiences the primary existential anxiety: he is bound to relinquish his secure, all-encompassing intrauterine life and has to live with augmenting separation. To a large extent, alienation is inherent to any extrauterine life. When the infant is reared, love and nurture are given almost unconditionally for he is helpless and cannot survive without mothering. Pathological interactions with the mothering one and later with other members of the family will produce mawkish interpersonal transactions. The psychological development of the growing child is arrested and he withdraws himself from ordinary human relations. Yet his ripening mind and body seek to have intimacy and warmth. This makes him extremely susceptible to religions and dogmatic ideologies. The process of conversion usually occurs during the juvenile and adolescent stages, after which the individual will experience a variety of religious feelings, ranging from masochistic submission to mystical communion.

In general, past familial derivatives and socialization experience are the major determinants of the susceptibility of an individual to religious or ideological conversion. This process, per se, is a vicious circle: when such conversion happens, the individual will regress to his syndrome of fixation in his developmental stage. Thus, it is possible that he may show maturity before people but feels as an infant before the mythical figures of his religion or the doctrines of his ideology. Growing under the 'loving' and vigilant eyes of Mother or Mother-substitute is his most pleasurable and blissful time at all. In actions, he may demonstrate great strength and determination. Nonetheless, he is a fetus at heart, absolutely dependent on his mythical figures for guidance and spiritual support. By distorting the reality and erecting a system of fata morgana, the convert manages to abide in his phantasy system, entertaining that these can give him a sense of identity and the meaning of life. The more he is caught in his ultimate concern, the more his experiential structure is closed to the objective reality, and vice versa, ~~to~~ ad infinitum.